

Cereal presents Part II of:

CADENCE

A Faerie Tale by Robert Mac Kay

The trapped wing was rendered apart and the spring was spent and we tumbled to the ground. Through my tears and my blood I saw the blue haired laughing. She was laughing hysterically. And then I blacked out...

Thus began the darkest hours of my life. Having been delivered to my home, and too, my prison, by my friends, I could find no solace. What remained of my wings, my beautiful wings, were tightly wrapped in fresh cherry skins and splinted with some toothpicks I had remaining. For a time, Thistle came to me three times a day to nurse me in my bed as I could not eat and was feverish with infection. Snapper proved to be a true flower and brought provisions in great number and set to preserving them in sunlight every day. This would keep me in good spirits though we all knew well enough that a faerie with no wings was but a shadow and not long to live unaided. From that day I would be dependent on others for my life should I survive at all, and this was a burden I would never bestow upon these sweet faeries.

The last request I made of my friends was to squeak me some items with which I may adjust to my new self. Those tools I would use to fetch food and protect myself from ravenous beasts and birds. And my list was such:

- 1) A rough stone to shape tools
- 2) A flat blade of metal for cutting
- 3) Thread
- 4) Flat wood

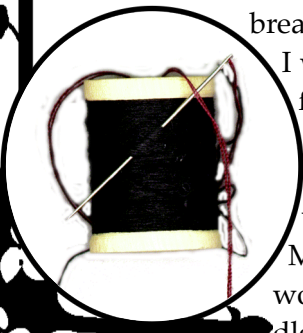
Only those few things and I would allow them to serve me no longer. If life were to be my fate, I would live by my own hands and my own toils.

And toil I did. The first thing my home needed was level flooring, as I was now poorly balanced. My nest was hitherto unfurnished with such a thing as I would never need it. A hop and burst of wing beat would easily deliver me to my ceiling and to my bed, but now I must climb and walk and use my feet like a...human (no offense). I had completed my floors and ladders in little time, securing them with thread and trying to preserve as much space as I could, these conveniences inhabiting so precious much.

In my tenth day of seclusion, having never dared venture from my home, I removed the wraps from my wings to monitor their recovery. It was with the darkest dread that I saw what lay before me. The bandages had done nothing. Both wings were desiccated, withered as old leaves of autumn. The next morning they fell off. Believe me, this was truly devastating and I failed to cope with my terrible affliction. Mourning the loss of my poor dead wings, weeping, wailing and beating my

breast, throwing myself in tantrums against the floor, I envisioned every horrible way I would surely die- starvation, thirst, suicide, attack by animals, falling. O! what a fate! Once a faerie, lit to the sky with such fancy, now fearing every height that now would surely kill me. Doomed to burrow into the dirt, so that any fall would be one of my own height, or trapped like a kitten in a tree: afraid of my door and windows, and the Earth, the Mother rushing upon me to smash my every bone. My lack of wings, too, made my life cold. With no wings to stretch into the sun I would always chill. I must soon insulate my home and my own body, thus, my needle and blade.

I took kindly to maple trees my whole life, mostly for their smell, and mostly for their amber, sweetness was such the reward for the effort of tapping. And in that time (my life) I had made many observations, most important of these was this. In



autumn, trees shed their canopies and expose themselves to the brute of winter. The maple produced a most peculiar leaf that, when falling from the host, makes a most graceful and slow decent to the Earth. I therefore reasoned my escape to the ground.

Having collected a dozen or more such wonders, I pierced their dense pits with my needle and ran my thread through each one. With less difficulty, I tied a harness together with careful knots. I poised on the edge of my window, one arm full of threads, the other armed with my needle and blade, and prayed to the Mother for the gifts of my past and the reclamation of my future.

I do believe I that I screamed the entire way down, falling for the first time in my life, the leaves whirring madly over my head. Yet I landed quite softly and quite safely much to my relief, and, frankly, to my surprise. But I did not dwell on the moment, carefully wrapping up my invention and stowing it at the foot of my tree, my needle and blade at my side, I hunted for my needs for the first time. By the end of the day I returned to my tree with three mouse skins, the largest of which I had already crafted into a large and very good stack. I climbed my tree, feeling an odd burning in my legs and shoulders, my sack of sins and leaves on my back.

From that day, I had developed some rituals to ensure my survival. Most importantly, to always keep my needle beside me, lest I be attacked. Secondly, every third day I would drop from my nest with my sack to gather food. Though I was quite used to sweet fruits and nectars, I surely had to develop a taste for more base sustenance: roots, mushrooms, seeds, and any fruit low to or on the ground. Eventually, with the periodic acquisitions of skins, I even took some of the flesh and fats of mice. This, it seemed, did well for my substantial growth in muscle, though I was lighter now than before my handicap. Thirdly, I spent many hours trapping insects of flight and observing birds and studying the very nature of flight, which I once could do quite well, never understanding how. I even experimented in replacement wings, though having

no part on my body left to attach them, I would never truly use them. My arms had neither the strength nor the stamina for such a thing.

One day, searching for food, I found a most dreaded item, a machine, a small clock in the grass. I started at it and examined it with awe for a time before my blood boiled with rage. I savagely beat at it with my needle and blade and tore it asunder, scattering gears and springs and glass.

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My mind and heart seethed with mad rage, and I was quite out of my head. When I saw what lay before me as my emotions ebbed, I was filled at once with rapture and obsession. My salvation lay before me in many scattered bits. I emptied my sack of seeds and gathered the many pieces of the clock and scurried home.

I spent one spring plus another in endless pursuit of tiny clocks and like machines, studying their mechanics and experimenting with them. I had squeaked nearly twenty and their many bodies littered my home. The wonder of these machines never failed to amaze me; that a human, so obviously a clumsy creature to see in movement and in nature, could construct so delicate and so precise a machine. With my knowledge of natural things and the powers locked from human eyes, I set to making wings of unnatural design.

Also, all I could construct was a machine that could but move wings, and not wings themselves. Despite my efforts and capturing even the largest of flying insects, I could not produce wings sturdy enough for my beautiful machine. So obsessed was I at this time, I rambled horrid thoughts of angry retribution, anger at the Mother and my brain for failing me when I was so close to my goal. I even went so far as to blame dear sweet Snapper for my condition, when I concluded: no, not Snapper, but another.

To be continued next week...

Cereal is looking for authors to contribute prose. Contact diablo@cs.h.rit.edu for details.